

KSRTC Established 1961

Be it introducing palmtop electronic ticketing machines or outsourcing officer recruitment to IIM-B, KSRTC's radical changes in transportation in Karnataka have achieved many firsts

ROUTE CAUSE

This state government undertaking holds the distinction for coming up with a series of firsts, thanks to its emphasis on innovation. Established in 1961, the Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC), which has 30,000 workers on board, was the first to introduce a computerised passenger seat reservation system and deploy palmtop electronic ticketing machines (ETMS). The latter won the KSRTC a national award at a show on urban mobility in Delhi last year. The reasons couldn't have been more justifiable. The palmtop ETMS

have not only made paper tickets relics of the past but also helped conductors handle schedules, routes and check fee collection details at the press of a button. Nearly 8,000 ETMS are in operation in about 6,600 buses across the state that ferry nearly 2.5 million passengers traversing 2 million km every day. The endeavour has helped KSRTC generate a gross revenue of Rs 1,600 crore this year. The state government undertaking also had its own website as early as 1997.

There are other achievements. The state transport un-

dertaking helped raise a Rs 30-crore corpus to set up a first-of-its-kind research centre in India on transport, infrastructure and urban planning at the Indian Institute of Science campus. It was the highest financial aid from a state government given to an individual centre at India's premier science institute. The KSRTC has outsourced officer recruitment to the leading B-school Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore (IIM-B), earlier this month. This is perhaps the first time a premier B-school is involved in such an exercise to increase transparency. IIM-B will conduct the test, evaluate the papers and make the final selection list for the Grade 1 and Grade 2 officers for the KSRTC. Jobs were advertised on KSRTC's website and nearly 44,000 applications came online.

Rs 5 crore
is the revenue generated by the Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation daily.

The state transport undertaking along with the Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation is the first in the country to have the highest number of high-end buses—750 Volvo, and now Mercedes, buses. Yet the city is not

resting on the laurels brought by its state transport bodies. Karnataka has scored a record in being the first state to deploy buses under the Central government's city modernisation scheme, the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission (JNNURM), in which the Urban Development Ministry will give grants of Rs 5,000 crore in 65 cities to buy 15,000 luxury buses. The state government Transport Department Secretary M.K. Shankaralinge Gowda, an IAS officer, who is steering much of the projects on the road to success, says, "At the end of the day, you have to provide the best for the end user, the passenger, and that is what drives us to constantly raise the bar." Indeed, KSRTC's consistent efforts have pressed the accelerator in pioneering successful urban transport paradigms in the country.

by Stephen David



M.K. Shankaralinge Gowda 56, Secretary, Transport Department

"We want to use high technology, state-of-the-art vehicles and adapt professional management to ensure comfort to our passengers."